

mode has the interface in ncurses and you have to use your keyboard to run a menu-driven application. The third is the background mode or the daemon mode.

Non-interactive mode: In this mode, you have to pass arguments to the application from the shell and run it. This mode does not start the ncurses-based user interface but only dumps the output to STDOUT (in this case, the shell). You'll find a list of all valid arguments along with their descriptions in the man page.

Interactive mode: When you run Calcurse without passing any arguments to it, you will see an interface as shown in Figure 1. This is the mode we are going to concentrate on in this article. You can go through the three sections (appointments, calendar and tasks) using TAB. (Remember, all the keys mentioned in the review are according to the default key-bindings. You can change them to match your needs.) The active section will have a border colour that's different from the other three sections. The section names are quite self-explanatory. The only thing I could not understand in this interface was the symbols to the left of the date in the appointments section. It turns out that they correspond to the phase of the moon on the current date.

- ' | ' – First quarter of the moon.
- ' () ' – Full moon.
- ' | ' – Last quarter of the moon.
- ' | ' – New moon.
- ' ' – (No sign) Phase does not correspond to one of the descriptions above.

The notification bar at the bottom of the three sections displays the current date and time, followed by the file where the calendar database is stored ('apts' in Figure 1, which is the default file), along with the time remaining for the start of the next appointment (not shown in Figure 1) in the following 24 hours.

Finally, right at the very bottom is the status bar. It displays the current key-bindings along with the actions tied to them.

Background mode: In order for Calcurse to run in background mode, the daemon mode option has to be enabled in the configuration files or via the interactive mode. When enabled, the daemon automatically kicks in when you close the interactive mode and, similarly, stops working when the interactive mode is started again.

When in the background mode, Calcurse keeps a check on the upcoming appointments and executes the predefined notification command whenever necessary. You can check if Calcurse is running in the background by passing the `--status` argument to the application, which gives you the PID of the process if it is running.

Using Calcurse

Let's now look at how to use Calcurse in the interactive mode. As mentioned earlier, the status bar is quite self-explanatory; besides, you can always use '?' to open help. You have to use `Ctrl+p` and `Ctrl+n` for the previous and next page in Help. I will not go into more details here.

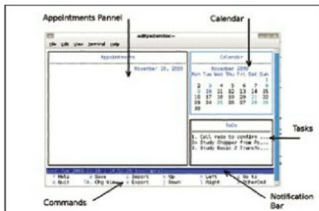


Figure 1: Main window (right after you launch Calcurse)



Figure 2: UI colour settings

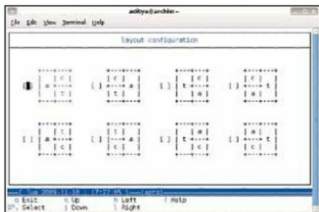


Figure 3: UI layout options

The documentation is very good and there shouldn't be any problem in using it. Now, we will go into the details regarding the configurations. Pressing `c` takes you to the configuration menu.

The configuration menu has subcategories, namely the General Settings, Layout, Notify, Colour and Key-bindings. (Pressing the capitalised letter takes you to that particular sub-menu.) Under the general options, you can set the options regarding auto-save, the auto-save time interval, starting of the week, date formats, etc.